

Przeworski et al 2000 Claude Guide

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1 Central Claims

- Political regimes should be classified **dichotomously**, as either **democracy** or **dictatorship**, rather than scored on a continuous or graded scale (e.g., Polity's -10 to $+10$). Continuous indices conflate analytically distinct attributes of regimes (contestation, participation, civil liberties, etc.) into a single index number, obscuring rather than clarifying the causal structure of regime dynamics.
- A regime is coded **democratic** if and only if it satisfies minimal procedural criteria: the chief executive is elected (or responsible to an elected legislature), the legislature is elected, more than one party competes, and—crucially—an **alternation in power under electoral rules has occurred or could occur**. This is the “ACLP” or “DD” (Democracy-Dictatorship) dataset, one of the most widely used regime-classification datasets in comparative politics.
- Democracy is defined procedurally as **contestation**, not substantively as good outcomes, rights, or welfare. Following Schumpeter and Dahl, democracy is “a system of processing conflicts in which outcomes depend on what participants do, but no single force controls what occurs and its outcomes.” The defining feature is **uncertainty of outcomes within certainty of procedures/rules**—an institutionalized equilibrium of contestation, not the absence of conflict.
- The book's most famous empirical finding directly **overturns the causal mechanism** of classical modernization theory: economic development (higher GDP per capita) does **not** make the *transition* to democracy more likely. Dictatorships do not become significantly more likely to democratize as they grow richer. What development *does* do is make existing democracies dramatically more likely to **survive**. This is often called the **Przeworski-Limongi finding** (also previewed in their earlier 1997 *World Politics* article).
- The famous **\$6,000 threshold** (in 1985 PPP dollars): among the 135 or so democracies observed 1950–1990, no democracy ever fell once per capita income exceeded roughly \$6,000 (Argentina in 1975, at about \$6,055, is the closest and often-cited near-exception before its fall to military coup in 1976, though this exact case is debated). Below that threshold, democracies are fragile and exit at a rate that is a strict, monotonically declining function of income.
- Lipset's modernization theory (1959) is therefore reinterpreted: what Lipset and subsequent cross-sectional modernization scholars actually documented was a **stationary/equilibrium association**—richer countries tend to be democracies—not necessarily a causal claim that development produces transitions. Przeworski and Limongi show this association is generated primarily by **selection/survival**, not by development-induced transition. Democracies are “born” at all levels of income (essentially exogenously, as if by historical accident, political crisis, or elite bargaining), but only survive where income is high; poor democracies regress to dictatorship at a high rate, mechanically producing the cross-sectional correlation between wealth and democracy.

- This reframes the entire “endogenous” vs. “exogenous” theories of democratization debate: the **endogenous** view (Lipset-style: development causes democratization) is empirically rejected for transitions; the **exogenous** view (democratization is largely independent of a country’s own economic trajectory—driven by political contingency, elite conflict, diffusion, or external shocks) fits the transition data better. But conditional on democracy existing, economic performance is powerfully **endogenous to regime survival**.
- Political institutions and economic performance: over 1950–1990, aggregate per capita **growth rates** do not differ dramatically between democracies and dictatorships on average, but the **mechanisms** generating growth differ sharply. Dictatorships tend to grow (when they do) via higher rates of physical **investment** and a lower labor share of income (workers are repressed and consume less, capital accumulates faster); democracies exhibit higher **labor productivity growth**, less volatile growth, and grow with less reliance on investment suppression of consumption. Population growth is also lower in democracies (via lower fertility, correlated with the same underlying development-level effects), meaning democracies perform relatively better in per-capita terms than aggregate GDP comparisons alone suggest.
- Political instability—coups, government crises, cabinet changes—is more common in poor countries and interacts with regime type: dictatorships are, on net, not obviously more stable than democracies once controlling for income; poor democracies are exceptionally unstable, but this instability is a function of poverty, not of democracy per se.

2 Empirical Strategy and Data

- **Universe of cases:** 141 countries, 1950–1990 (or from independence/data availability), yielding over 4,000 country-year observations—at the time, one of the most comprehensive cross-national political-economic panels assembled.
- **The dichotomous regime measure (DD/ACLP):** Built from four rules applied to observable facts (not expert judgment or perception surveys): (1) the executive must be elected; (2) the legislature must be elected; (3) there must be more than one party contesting elections; (4) an alternation in power must have occurred (or, for the first-ever election in a country’s history, credible ex ante uncertainty must exist). This is explicitly designed to be **replicable and low-inference**, in contrast to Polity’s coder-judgment-based composite scoring of “institutionalized democracy” and “institutionalized autocracy.”
- **Critique of graded/continuous measures (Polity, Freedom House):** Aggregating multiple conceptually distinct components (competitiveness of participation, openness/competitiveness of executive recruitment, constraints on the executive) into a single continuous score assumes these components trade off linearly and are commensurable. Przeworski et al. argue this is conceptually incoherent—regimes are qualitatively different *types* of equilibria (contested vs. not), not points on a single latent continuum—and empirically consequential, since duration/survival analyses and transition models are sensitive

to how the threshold between “democracy” and “not democracy” is drawn.

- **Survival/duration analysis:** The core statistical technique is a hazard-rate/duration model of regime survival as a function of income, growth, and other covariates—asking, conditional on being a democracy (or dictatorship) of a given type in year t , what is the probability of regime change by $t + 1$? This lets them separate the “birth” (transition) process from the “death” (survival) process, which continuous indices and simple cross-sectional regressions conflate.
- **Key covariates:** GDP per capita (level and growth), income inequality (where available), sectoral composition (percent of labor force in agriculture), international/regional diffusion (proportion of neighboring countries that are democracies), and prior regime history (past transitions, age of the current regime).
- **Growth accounting:** Investment share of GDP, capital stock growth, labor force growth, and total factor productivity are decomposed separately for democratic and dictatorial regime-years to identify *how*, not just *whether*, growth differs by regime type.
- **Robustness checks:** The authors show the survival finding (income $\rightarrow$ democratic durability) holds across sub-periods, regions, and alternative income thresholds, and is not an artifact of any single case (e.g., dropping Argentina 1975–76 does not change the substantive conclusion, though it is the most commonly cited stress-test of the \$6,000 claim).

3 Core Works Cited

- **Seymour Martin Lipset**, “Some Social Requisites of Democracy” (1959, *American Political Science Review*)—the foundational modernization-theory statement that economic development (wealth, urbanization, education, industrialization) is causally linked to democracy; Przeworski et al. reinterpret Lipset’s correlational finding as a survival effect rather than a transition effect.
- **Robert Dahl**, *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition* (1972)—the immediate conceptual ancestor of the book’s procedural/minimalist definition of democracy as contestation (public contestation) plus inclusiveness (participation); Przeworski et al. operationalize a Dahl-style minimalist conception into a binary empirical measure.
- **Joseph Schumpeter**, *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy* (1942)—the source of the “democracy as a method,” competitive-elite-selection definition of democracy that underlies the ACLP procedural criteria (elections as the mechanism, not any particular substantive outcome).
- **Guillermo O’Donnell and Philippe Schmitter**, *Transitions from Authoritarian Rule* (1986)—the “transitology” literature emphasizing elite bargaining, contingency, and agency in democratic transitions; Przeworski et al.’s exogenous/contingent view of transitions is broadly compatible with and empirically extends this tradition.

- **Barrington Moore**, *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (1966)—the classic structuralist account linking class coalitions (commercialized agriculture, bourgeoisie, landed elites) to regime outcomes; Przeworski et al. engage this tradition by testing whether economic/structural variables predict transitions as Moore-style theories would imply, and largely find they do not (for transitions specifically).
- **Adam Przeworski and Fernando Limongi**, “Modernization: Theories and Facts” (1997, *World Politics*)—the direct precursor article previewing the book’s central empirical finding (development predicts survival, not transition) with a shorter dataset and simpler tests.
- **Samuel Huntington**, *Political Order in Changing Societies* (1968)—the modernization-era account this book directly complicates: Huntington links development to instability via a gap between mobilization and institutionalization; Przeworski et al. instead find development stabilizes existing democratic institutions rather than straightforwardly determining regime type or producing praetorian instability.
- **Dankwart Rustow**, “Transitions to Democracy: Toward a Dynamic Model” (1970, *Comparative Politics*)—an early argument that the preconditions for a stable democracy differ from the preconditions for its founding; a direct conceptual predecessor to the book’s transition/survival distinction.
- **Douglass North**, *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (1990)—background for the book’s treatment of political institutions as constraints that structure economic incentives (investment, property rights), relevant to the growth-mechanism chapters.

4 Part I: Classifying Political Regimes

- **Why dichotomous, not continuous:** The authors argue that “democracy” and “dictatorship” are qualitatively distinct **types** of political equilibria—in a democracy, incumbents can and do lose office through institutionalized procedures; in a dictatorship, they cannot be removed through those procedures (removal happens through coups, death, or other extra-institutional means). Because this is a discrete, either/or property, forcing it onto a continuous scale (as Polity does, combining constraint-on-executive, competitiveness-of-participation, and openness-of-recruitment sub-scores) manufactures false precision and can create measurement error that biases downstream statistical analyses (e.g., regressing growth on a continuous democracy score assumes a linear dose-response relationship that may not exist).
- **The four coding rules operationalized:** (1) Chief executive must be chosen by popular election or by a body itself popularly elected; (2) legislature must be popularly elected; (3) there must be more than one party competing (excludes single-party “elections”); (4) there must have been at least one peaceful **alternation in power** under the same electoral rules, or—if the regime is “new”—ex ante uncertainty about the outcome must be judged

credible. Regimes failing any criterion are coded dictatorship.

- **Handling ambiguous/borderline cases:** The book devotes considerable attention to coding decisions (e.g., dominant-party democracies like Mexico under the PRI, or Botswana, which never experienced alternation but is widely considered democratic by other measures)—illustrating the tradeoffs of a bright-line rule: transparency and replicability at the cost of occasionally coding intuitively-democratic-seeming cases as dictatorships (or vice versa) until an alternation actually occurs.
- **Comparisons with other measures:** The book explicitly benchmarks the DD/ACLP measure against Polity and Freedom House, showing substantial but incomplete overlap, with the disagreements concentrated in a predictable set of hybrid/hegemonic-party regimes. This sets up an enduring methodological debate in the discipline about the tradeoffs between minimalist/procedural (dichotomous) and maximalist/substantive (graded) conceptions of democracy.
- **Democracy as equilibrium, not consensus:** The definitional chapter’s key theoretical move is to define democracy not by *what* outcomes occur but by *how* outcomes are generated: “a system of processing conflicts in which outcomes depend on what participants do, but no single force controls what occurs and its outcomes.” Order is not imposed from outside the system of contestation; it emerges endogenously from institutionalized uncertainty—actors comply with adverse outcomes because the rules of the game make future contestation possible. This makes democracy inherently about **bounded uncertainty**: unpredictable in particular outcomes, predictable in its procedures.

5 Part II: What Democracy Does—and Does Not—Require of Development

- **Reframing modernization theory:** Lipset (1959) observed that rich countries are more likely to be democracies. Przeworski et al. ask: is this because (a) development causes autocracies to democratize (an **endogenous**/modernization mechanism), or (b) democracies simply survive better once rich, regardless of how or why they became democratic in the first place (a **survival/selection** mechanism), with regime origins being comparatively **exogenous** to a country’s economic trajectory?
- **The core test:** Using the hazard-rate framework, they separately estimate (1) the probability that a dictatorship transitions to democracy as a function of income, and (2) the probability that a democracy fails (reverts to dictatorship) as a function of income. Finding (1): no statistically robust relationship between income level/growth and the probability of transition to democracy. Finding (2): a strong, monotonic, and robust negative relationship between income and the probability of democratic breakdown.
- **The \$6,000 threshold in detail:** No democracy with per capita income above roughly \$6,000 (1985 PPP) died in the sample period. Below that level, democratic survival is

essentially a lottery correlated with income—poorer democracies fail at markedly higher rates. This produces the observed cross-sectional wealth-democracy correlation almost entirely through differential **survival** (a ‘selection’ story), not because poor authoritarian regimes are becoming democratic as they industrialize.

- **Implication for modernization theory:** Lipset’s requisites are “requisites for the survival of democracy... not for its emergence”—a fundamental reinterpretation. Development does not push dictatorships toward democracy in this dataset; new democracies emerge for reasons largely independent of a country’s development level (military defeat, elite splits, economic crisis of the dictatorship itself, international pressure, diffusion/contagion from regional neighbors, etc.)—but once democracy is present, rising income makes it durable.
- **Mechanisms proposed for the survival effect:** At higher incomes, the stakes of losing office are lower relative to a country’s total wealth (redistributive conflict is less zero-sum); a larger middle class has more to lose from instability and more capacity to organize in defense of the constitutional order; and higher income is associated with more diversified economies where no single actor (e.g., a landed elite or a single natural-resource sector) can seize total control of the state’s spoils. The book is candid that the paper documents the empirical pattern more convincingly than it nails down the precise causal mechanism.
- **Regional/diffusion effects:** The probability of both transition and survival is also shaped by regional context—democracies are more likely to survive (and dictatorships more likely to fall) in periods/regions where a higher proportion of neighboring states are democracies, an early empirical anticipation of the “diffusion” and “waves of democratization” literatures (cf. Huntington’s “third wave”).

6 Part III: Political Institutions, Growth, and Well-Being

- **Headline growth finding:** Average annual per capita GDP growth rates are not dramatically different between democracies and dictatorships across the full 1950–1990 sample—a finding that, at the time, cut against both a pro-authoritarian “developmental dictatorship” narrative (the East Asian “authoritarian advantage” thesis) and a naive pro-democratic-growth narrative.
- **Divergent growth mechanisms:** Despite similar aggregate growth, the *composition* of growth differs. Dictatorships tend to grow through higher rates of **physical capital investment**, often financed by **depressing wages/labor’s share of income** (repression of labor organizing lowers consumption, raising the savings/investment rate). Democracies grow with comparatively higher **labor productivity** gains and are less reliant on investment-forcing/wage suppression.
- **Population growth:** Population (and fertility) growth is systematically **lower in democracies**, plausibly through channels like female education, public health provision, and so

cial insurance. Because per capita growth is (GDP growth) minus (population growth), democracies' comparative advantage is understated by looking at aggregate GDP growth alone—their per capita welfare performance is relatively better than raw GDP comparisons suggest, once population dynamics are taken into account.

- **Volatility:** Growth in dictatorships is documented as more **volatile**—more boom-bust, with both higher upside episodes and more severe collapses—consistent with the idea that dictatorial growth strategies (investment-forcing, dependence on a narrow elite's continued cooperation) are less institutionally robust to shocks or succession crises than democratic growth strategies.
- **Political instability and coups:** Instability (cabinet crises, coups, irregular leader turnover) is strongly predicted by **poverty**, largely independent of regime type; poor democracies and poor dictatorships are both unstable, while rich democracies and (to a lesser extent) rich dictatorships are both comparatively stable. This again supports the book's broader thesis that income, not regime type per se, is doing much of the explanatory work often mistakenly attributed to institutions alone.
- **Normative upshot:** Because aggregate growth performance is roughly a wash, the book argues that the choice between democracy and dictatorship should not be adjudicated primarily on growth-maximization grounds (contra some modernization-adjacent, growth-first arguments for authoritarian development strategies)—the case for democracy rests on procedural/normative grounds (contestation, accountability, avoidance of catastrophic risk under dictatorship) rather than a growth dividend.

7 Methodological Contributions and Limitations

- **Contribution: separating transition from survival:** The book's central methodological innovation is showing that pooled cross-sectional regressions of “democracy level” on “income” conflate two distinct causal processes (transition and survival) that can—and here do—have opposite implications. This is a durable lesson for regime-type/political-economy research generally: always ask whether a correlation reflects selection/survival dynamics before inferring a causal transition mechanism.
- **Contribution: a transparent, replicable coding rule:** The DD/ACLP measure's minimal-inference, rule-based coding was explicitly designed to reduce the subjectivity and potential endogeneity-to-outcomes present in expert-coded indices like Polity (where, critics argued, coders' assessments of “institutionalized democracy” could be influenced by knowledge of a country's subsequent trajectory or performance).
- **Critique: construct validity of the dichotomy:** Critics (and later measures like V-Dem, and refinements by Cheibub, Gandhi, and Vreeland's 2010 update of the dataset itself) argue the bright-line alternation rule can misclassify long-lived dominant-party democracies (pre-2000 Mexico, Botswana, Japan under LDP dominance, Singapore-adjacent cases) as non-democracies simply because no alternation has yet occurred, even when con-

testation is otherwise genuine—an argument that the measure trades conceptual purity for a specific kind of measurement error correlated with regime durability itself.

- **Critique: functionalism in survival analysis:** Some critics charge that explaining democratic survival by its economic “payoffs” to elites/citizens risks a functionalist logic (democracy persists because it is advantageous) without fully specifying the micro-level strategic mechanism by which elites/actors choose to comply rather than defect at any given income level; the book’s own game-theoretic framing (elsewhere developed in Przeworski’s *Democracy and the Market*, 1991) is only partially integrated into the empirical survival chapters.
- **Critique: does the \$6,000 threshold still hold?:** Subsequent scholarship has questioned whether the sharp threshold is an artifact of the 1950–1990 sample. China’s continued authoritarian durability at income levels now far above \$6,000 (in updated PPP terms) is frequently invoked as a potential counterexample to any strong version of the wealth-guarantees-democracy-survival claim, though defenders note the original claim concerns *democratic* survival, not *whether* dictatorships eventually democratize at high income—so China (a durable, high-income *dictatorship*) is arguably consistent with, not contrary to, the book’s actual claim (which never asserted ‘all rich countries become/stay democracies,’ only that observed *democracies* above the threshold did not fail in-sample).
- **Critique: causal identification for the survival effect:** While the correlational pattern (income → survival) is extremely robust, the book is more successful establishing the pattern than isolating an exogenous source of variation in income to fully rule out reverse causality or omitted common causes (e.g., some deeper institutional quality driving both wealth and democratic durability)—a critique frequently leveled by later instrumental-variables-oriented work (e.g., Acemoglu, Johnson, Robinson, and Yared’s subsequent challenges to the income-democracy link using country fixed effects, which found the correlation weakens considerably within-country).
- **Data/measurement limitations:** The 1950–1990 window necessarily excludes the post-Cold War “third wave” consolidation period and the 21st-century cases (post-Soviet states, the Arab Spring, contemporary democratic backsliding) that have become central to subsequent regime-survival research—later updates to the DD dataset (Cheibub, Gandhi, and Vreeland 2010, extending through 2008) and competing datasets (Boix-Miller-Rosato, V-Dem’s Regimes of the World) extend and partially revise the empirical picture.

8 Connections to the Broader Literature

- **Huntington 1968:** This book is in many ways a direct empirical rejoinder to modernization-era theorizing about development and political order. Huntington worried that rapid modernization could *outpace* institutionalization, producing praetorian instability; Przeworski et al. instead find that higher income robustly *stabilizes* whatever regime (especially democratic) already exists, and that transitions themselves are not well predicted by development at all—development’s political effect is on durability, not directly on the

mobilization-institutionalization gap Huntington emphasized.

- **Dahl 1972:** The book’s operational definition of democracy is a direct descendant of Dahl’s polyarchy (contestation plus participation), converted from Dahl’s largely conceptual/typological treatment into a binary, replicable empirical coding rule—extending Dahl’s framework into large-N quantitative political economy.
- **Moore 1966:** Where Moore explains regime *type* (democracy, fascism, communism) via class-coalition structural history, Przeworski et al. test whether structural/economic variables predict regime *transitions* in a large panel and find comparatively weak support for structural/developmental determinism in transitions specifically—an important qualification (not outright refutation) of Moore-style structuralist accounts, since Moore’s theory was historically contingent on specific national class configurations rather than a general claim about income levels driving transitions.
- **Putnam 1993:** Both books challenge simple modernization-style stories (Putnam: civic community, not wealth, drives government performance; Przeworski et al.: wealth drives democratic *survival*, not democratic *emergence*), and both insist on disaggregating a phenomenon (institutional performance; regime change) into distinct causal processes rather than treating it as a single undifferentiated outcome.
- **Cox 1997:** Cox’s work on electoral systems and coordination presumes the underlying regime is a functioning, contested democracy (Duvergerian coordination logics operate *within* the space of institutionalized contestation that Przeworski et al. use to define democracy in the first place); Przeworski et al. supply the macro-level boundary conditions (does contestation/alternation exist at all) within which Cox’s meso-level electoral-system arguments become relevant.
- **Lijphart 1999:** Lijphart’s majoritarian/consensus typology, like Cox’s, is a study of variation *among* democracies; Przeworski et al.’s prior, coarser classification (democracy vs. dictatorship) is the necessary first cut that makes Lijphart’s finer-grained institutional comparisons meaningful—and their critique of continuous indices is a methodological cousin to debates over how to code Lijphart’s own executives-parties and federal-unitary dimensions.
- **Weber 1930 (Protestant Ethic):** More distant, but relevant: Weber’s account of the cultural/religious origins of capitalist development is one strand of the broader “development causes X” tradition (development causing rationalization, disciplined labor, etc.) that Lipset’s modernization theory of democracy extended to politics; Przeworski et al.’s finding complicates any simple, unidirectional development-to-democracy pipeline in the Weberian-modernization lineage, though the book does not engage Weber directly.
- **Huber and Shipan 2002:** Huber and Shipan study legislative delegation and bureaucratic autonomy *within* established democracies—again presupposing the Przeworski et al. threshold condition (a genuinely contested regime) as the space within which such institutional-design questions (contract length, statutory detail) are meaningful; both

share a rational-institutionalist methodological commitment to precise, falsifiable operationalization of institutional concepts.

- **Powell 2000:** Powell’s work on election rules, representation, and accountability (and his interest in majoritarian vs. proportional visions of democracy) again operates within the domain of “democracies” as Przeworski et al. define them; Powell’s normative concern with how well elections translate votes into accountability is complementary to, but distinct from, Przeworski et al.’s more minimalist, procedural definitional threshold.
- **Stokes 2013 (*Brokers, Voters, and Clientelism*):** Stokes’s analysis of clientelism and vote-buying is highly relevant to the book’s discussion of borderline “dominant-party” regimes (Mexico under the PRI) that satisfy some but not all DD criteria—clientelistic mobilization is precisely the mechanism by which some hegemonic-party regimes manufacture the appearance of contestation without genuine uncertainty of outcomes, illustrating the practical difficulty of the DD coding rule’s alternation criterion in real cases.
- **Svolik 2012 (*The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*):** Svolik’s work picks up almost exactly where this book’s dictatorship-side analysis leaves off, developing a much richer typology and theory of authoritarian power-sharing, succession, and durability (distinguishing military, single-party, personalist, and monarchic dictatorships) than the binary “dictatorship” category here allows—a natural and often-cited extension/critique, since Przeworski et al. treat all non-democracies as a single category for coding purposes even though the causes of authoritarian survival plausibly differ enormously by dictatorship subtype.
- **Carey 2009 (*Legislative Voting and Accountability*):** Carey’s work on legislative behavior and accountability mechanisms operates squarely within the “democracy” category as defined by Przeworski et al., again illustrating how the DD dichotomy functions as a scope condition/gatekeeping variable for a large swath of subsequent institutionalist comparative politics research that studies variation *among* democracies.
- **Broader regime-classification debate:** The book helped launch a durable, ongoing methodological argument in comparative politics between dichotomous/minimalist measures (DD/ACLP, Boix-Miller-Rosato, Cheibub-Gandhi-Vreeland) and graded/maximalist measures (Polity, Freedom House, and later V-Dem’s multidimensional indices), with each side highlighting different tradeoffs between conceptual clarity/replicability and the loss of information about gradations of quality within regime types.